BIRDING LAKE ATALANTA, Rogers

LOCATION: Lake Atalanta Park is in Rogers. From 540, take the downtown exit (Walnut Street) east all the way through the old downtown to the railroad tracks. This is the corner of S. Arkansas & E. Walnut. Take E. Walnut east for roughly 7-8 blocks (downhill) to Lake Atalanta Park. There are parking areas on both sides of the road. A bathroom and water fountain are adjacent the parking area on the north (lake side) of the road.

HISTORY: Lake Atalanta was created in 1936 as part of a federal Works Progress Administration (WPA) project, at a time when government supported public projects that would employee people thrown out of work by the Great Depression. The earthen dam constructed across Prairie Creek impounded 40 acres. This served as the Rogers water supply from 1957 to 1970.

HABITATS: Habitats include the lake, Frisco Spring (a perennial Ozark spring with aquatic vegetation and bottomland forest), and mature upland forest. E. Walnut bisects the park. The lake and hillside forest are north of Walnut. Frisco Spring hollow lies south of Walnut. There are some striking examples of native plants (e.g., wild ginger) and huge mature trees. Some of the big old walnuts are awe-inspiring.

ACCESSIBILITY FOR THOSE WITH CHALLENGES: The paved roads provide good birding access for those with physical limitations. The hiking (or walking) trails are well-maintained and these are also fairly accessible.

BIRDING: Our typical birding trip consists of 2 short, slow walks. The **first part** is north of Walnut Street and covers the west edge of the lake; the area below the dam and includes a short trail in the forested hillside habitat above the lake. The **second part** of a typical trip includes part of the Frisco Springs trail south of Walnut.

First part: Typically, we'll park in the lot near the bathrooms and take off from there. We take the level, paved road traversing the lake's west side, looking at the gaggle of ducks and geese and waterfowl out on the lake, as well as checking the riparian forest along the road. Pileated Woodpeckers have nested in a huge old sycamore snag. We listen for birds on the hillside forest above. The gaggle of ducks and geese have included Ross's Goose, Snow Goose, and Cackling Goose, among the hordes of domestics providing much delight for those who enjoy feeding white bread to barnyard birds. Along the forested fringe we frequently see birds like Yellow Warblers in migration. In winter we see various dabbling as well as diving ducks. Buffleheads are common in winter, and we frequently see scaup (mostly Lesser, rarely Greater), Hooded Mergansers, and even the occasional rarity, like Long-tailed Duck and Surf Scoter. You always find American Crows there, but Fish Crows are dominant in summer. Look for, and listen for, the Red-shouldered Hawks.

We continue this leisurely walk north along the pavement to at least the bridge over the lake's outlet flow. Cliff Swallows nest under this bridge, and we often find Louisiana Waterthrushes in the continuation of Prairie Creek just past the bridge. This is a good place to sit, relax, and see what kind of birds are attracted to this area of flat water,

running water, bushes, trees, and exposed rocky hillside. The park area below the dam has been a good place to find Red-headed Woodpeckers. The combination of Prairie Creek bottomlands, mature trees (including big sycamores), and open spaces is attractive to many species all year. It's hard to miss Northern Parulas (summer) in such shady places.

From this area we backtrack south on the road. About half way between the dam and where we park, we take a trail that climbs into the uplands above the lake. This trail parallels the road below and comes out near the bathroom. All kinds of forest migrants turn up here. We look for the *Empidonax* flycatchers & have seen Yellow-bellied Flycatcher here, as well as the more commonly found migrants like Least Flycatcher.

Second Part: Now we're back to where we parked. We cross Walnut to the north part of the park. This is dominated by Frisco Spring and two forest slopes that form the hollow. Once again, it's an easy walk. You put your energy into watching and listening. We have seen Barred Owls in this hollow. Yellow-throated Vireos (summer) sing from the slopes. White-eyed Vireos sing from thickets along the spring. Jewelweed grows in big masses along the spring, attended by Ruby-throated Hummingbirds that form flocks late in the summer. There are pawpaw tree thickets along the trail, with their strange masses of reddish flowers in April. We usually explore the vegetation that grows along the spring run, because this is where we expect to see Mourning Warblers in migration.

Overall, Lake Atalanta is a highly attractive spot for birding because it includes much natural and artificial (lake) habitat, in a compact space. Many of the region's typical permanent residents can be found here, and the place really hops during migration fall-outs.